

Crimson King Maple

Acer platanoides 'Crimson King'



Origin

A cultivated variety of Norway maple first discovered as a chance red-leaved seedling around 1937 at a nursery in Limburg, Belgium, then introduced to the United States in the late 1940s.

Look for

Unlike most trees, its purple color isn't a fall event -- the leaves are purple from the moment they open in spring and stay that way all summer, making it easy to spot from blocks away.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf color: deep purple from spring through fall, not just autumn -- the clearest identifying trait.
- Leaf shape: five-lobed, hand-shaped like ordinary Norway maple.
- Bud: sharp-pointed, same structure as Norway maple.
- Commonly confused with: purple leaf plum (Crimson King's leaves are larger and maple-shaped, not oval).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Deep purple leaves unfurl, already colored from the very start of the season.
Summer	Foliage stays dark maroon-purple all season instead of turning green.
Fall	Color can deepen to an even darker purple-black before dropping.
Winter	Sharp-pointed buds on gray twigs, same structure as ordinary Norway maple.

DID YOU KNOW

- It was one of the earliest patented ornamental street trees in the US nursery trade, heavily promoted after its 1940s introduction.
- Its dark color comes from high levels of anthocyanin pigments that are normally only made in autumn in most trees -- this cultivar makes them all year.